The power of habit

Hi everyone! Welcome to this sixteenth episode of the Cottongue Podcast.

[00:00:13] As usual, I hope you're well. I'm very happy to see you again for this new podcast. I hope you're comfortably settled in to listen, or perhaps you're listening while doing something else, cooking, exercising or walking, for example. When I listen to podcasts to learn Polish, because I'm learning Polish, I like doing something else simultaneously. For example, I often listen while cooking, so I can do two things at once.

[00:01:06] When I was in France a few weeks ago, I read quite an interesting book and decided to make a podcast about it. It's by an American author, and its subject is the power of habit. It's quite popular, so perhaps you've read it, but today we'll discuss how it applies to language learning, particularly French.

[00:01:55] Some people think language learning has a magic recipe, something working for everyone, and buying a method lets us learn very quickly. Unfortunately, I don't believe that. I think regularity matters most. Perhaps you've seen polyglots' videos or read their blogs. They're very popular online, and we think these polyglots have an extraordinary talent for languages. On one hand, that's true. They're very talented, and perhaps learning ten or so languages isn't possible for everyone. But I think their real secret is using these languages daily, every day. Languages are often their profession: translators, interpreters, teachers. They spend their days thinking about language and using the foreign languages they know.

[00:03:39] Perhaps you've also heard of the ten-thousand-hour rule. It says becoming an expert, a specialist in a particular field, requires ten thousand hours of practice. To become a famous pianist, you must practise piano for ten thousand hours. Imagining what that amount represents is a little difficult. To give you an idea, playing piano for an hour daily would take twenty-seven years to reach ten thousand hours. Put that way, it's a little discouraging, but perhaps you don't want to become an expert. Perhaps your goal in French is simply understanding French films and communicating with French speakers.

[00:05:03] Besides, the ten-thousand-hour figure has been heavily criticised. Some experts disagree with this conclusion, this number. Some people take much longer to become very good in their discipline, while others take less time.

[00:05:31] In any case, I think the important thing is that mastering something requires a lot of time. To spend a lot of time doing something, the key to success, the most important thing, is regularity. Regularity is the only way to progress.

[00:05:59] If you exercise or play a musical instrument, you know regularity is most important, but unfortunately also hardest. So how can we make a practice regular?

[00:06:20] Simply by making it a habit. Easy to say, quite difficult to do! To help, today I'll discuss this book I read, written by Charles Duhigg. I'll discuss its conclusions, and in the second part give practical advice for making French a habit.

[00:07:02] Are you ready? Then here we go!

[00:07:16] In everyday life, we do many things without thinking. Perhaps the first thing you do in the morning is drink water, make coffee or go to the bathroom. Generally, you do this without thinking, because you've done it so often you're programmed to do it. You don't ask each morning whether to drink coffee or shower first. When you wake, you already, automatically know what you'll do. You do what you're accustomed to doing. It's a little like an aeroplane's autopilot.

[00:08:20] These habits concern not only your morning routine, but your whole life. Going to work, eating lunch, coming home in the evening: habits guide you.

[00:08:42] These habits are very practical because they make life easier. Why? Because our brain is lazy. It doesn't want too much effort, doesn't want to think or reflect, so it's very happy when autopilot can take over. Then the brain can rest and let autopilot take over. In his book, Charles Duhigg studied a patient whose brain was damaged after an accident. This patient had no memory, couldn't remember anything for more than a minute. When told something, after a few minutes he'd forgotten everything. Nevertheless, he could still learn new habits and repeat them unconsciously, without thinking. The brain area storing habits hadn't been damaged. This unconscious part guides our actions. Some habits are central and can influence our whole lives. They're very important. For example, exercise. When we exercise, we tend afterwards to eat healthily, sleep better, drink less alcohol, stop smoking and so on. Exercising affects our entire life. These are what we can call "keystone habits": habits capable of radically changing someone's life.

[00:11:19] Yet many people trying to develop these good habits don't succeed. You probably know New Year's resolutions, good decisions made at the year's beginning, like exercising or stopping smoking. You also know they're very difficult to keep. Often, a new year brings lots of good ideas and decisions, but after a few weeks we can't maintain them. We change our minds or abandon them. I go to the gym regularly, and January always brings many new members, but a few weeks later they disappear.

[00:12:23] So how can we make these good resolutions? We often think it's simply willpower. To stop smoking, you just need to want it. There are many methods: medication, therapies, hypnosis too. But without really wanting to stop, all these methods will be ineffective. Yet willpower doesn't explain everything. We must understand how habits work. Telling someone they failed because they lacked willpower is easy, but reality is more complex.

[00:13:30] How does a habit work? To understand, we must divide it into three parts.

[00:13:41] The first is the cue, meaning the thing triggering the habit, the thing starting it.

[00:13:56] The second is the routine: concretely, what you do when you see this cue, how you react.

[00:14:11] Finally, the third is the reward, meaning what the habit gives you, what you receive after the routine.

[00:14:26] I'll illustrate with an example to make understanding easier. Every afternoon at work, you take a break to buy a cake. This bad habit has caused a few extra kilos, and you want to lose the habit to lose the weight. To do that, you must identify its three stages precisely.

[00:15:08] First question: what's the cue? Is it the time? Do you always take your break at the same time? Or hunger? Do you take a break because you're hungry? Or perhaps boredom? You're bored, so decide to take a break. You must test to know precisely which cue triggers the habit.

[00:15:51] Then comes the routine. Here it's quite clear, easy to see: buying a cake and eating it.

[00:16:06] Finally, the reward. Perhaps it's the pleasure of taste, eating the cake, and sugar entering your blood. Or perhaps it's taking a break: you're pleased to stop working for a few minutes. Perhaps the reward is the cashier's smile. You may like the person working in the shop and want to see her. [00:16:56] The problem with this habit isn't the reward, but the routine. What do you think we can change in a habit? Can we change the cue? Not really, because you have no influence over it. But you can influence the routine, your response. That's precisely what must change: the routine. You must reprogramme your brain to react differently upon noticing the cue. If you do, the reward too can change.

[00:17:59] Now you're probably thinking again that saying this is easy, but doing it difficult. How can we change the routine, create a new habit? Once you've tested which cue triggers it, you can adopt a new routine in response.

[00:18:33] For example, if the cue is boredom, and you're bored every afternoon at work around four, find something to do for a few minutes to take your mind off things. Talk to a colleague, or take a short walk before returning to your desk. Distracting yourself for a few minutes means you'll no longer need cake and can lose the extra kilos.

[00:19:20] If the cue is hunger, if you're hungry around four every afternoon, bring fruit in the morning to eat later.

[00:19:37] That's the method for reprogramming the brain, changing a bad habit. But I think what interests you is developing a good habit, particularly making French practice a daily habit. That's what I'll discuss now: how to develop the habit of doing a little French every day.

[00:20:20] We'll return to a habit's structure. You know the first part is the cue, so find your own. Perhaps the time: decide to do thirty minutes of French every day at seven in the morning. A good way to provide this cue is simply setting a phone alarm. Or it could be entering the bus or metro: as soon as you're there, listen to a podcast, mine for example, or read a French article. It could also be driving, but then listening is the only option. Don't read behind the wheel! Cooking or going to the gym could also be cues.

[00:21:50] Next, adopt a routine to apply whenever the cue appears. It should resemble a little programme. Wondering what to do wastes time and isn't productive. If you prepare for French at seven without knowing where to begin, you'll waste time searching for an article or video, and probably end up procrastinating. Then there's a strong chance you'll abandon the habit. One routine might begin with rereading vocabulary. I imagine you have a notebook for vocabulary, so begin by reviewing it for five or ten minutes. Like exercise: first we warm up to prepare our muscles. The second part could be reading an article or watching a video for twenty minutes. A good idea is preparing the article or video the previous day. "The previous

day” means the day before. That way, you won’t waste time searching the next day. You’ll already know what to do. If you chose an article, you know you must read it. Or prepare a whole week’s programme each Sunday: “Monday I’ll listen to this podcast, Tuesday read this article, Wednesday do some grammar exercises”, and so on. A programme prepared in advance makes adopting and following the routine easier.

[00:24:44] Then, of course, the reward. That really depends on you. Perhaps a little chocolate, but be careful not to become addicted! Or if you have a programme, measure your progress: that progress is your reward. Week by week, you’ll know more words, understand harder things, and that’s your reward. You can also congratulate yourself: “Well done! Today, I learned ten new words.” Personally, after Polish, my reward is watching a YouTube video to relax. Perhaps not a very intelligent video, but a little reward after an effort. Yet if your routine is already enjoyable, if you enjoy doing it, it will also be its own reward. You won’t need chocolate to reward yourself.

[00:26:22] This habit mustn’t be a chore. A chore is something obligatory but unpleasant, like cleaning the house or washing dishes after eating: domestic chores. French practice mustn’t be a chore. It should be part of your life and give pleasure. Don’t forget why you’re learning, and present it positively. For example, if learning French for a job interview, say instead, “I’m learning French to advance my career, obtain a better position.” That’s a more positive way of presenting our goals.

[00:27:32] Daily French practice can become a keystone habit. Why? Daily contact with the language lets you improve comprehension quickly and, above all, think in French. That makes you want to do more and more French, until you do it without even noticing, unconsciously. For example, if you develop the habit of reading news in French, perhaps one day you’ll no longer notice what you’re reading is French, because it will have become completely natural.

[00:28:37] I also think remembering to change the routine occasionally matters, because keeping the same routine for months and months will probably become boring. We may feel we’re going round in circles. “Going round in circles” means not progressing, staying in the same place. A good way to break the routine is setting challenges, for example. They provide motivation to step outside your usual routine.

[00:29:39] In conclusion, applying these rules means French will eventually become part of your life. Once you reach a level sufficient for you, you can simply maintain it through enjoyable things: watching films, listening to the radio or reading articles regularly.

[00:30:17] That’s all for today. Thank you very much for listening. I hope this advice helps you practise French regularly. Perhaps you already do, in which case congratulations! If not, try applying some advice to make French an everyday thing. I insist because I think this truly is the key to success. Success needs regularity, meaning a habit.

[00:31:06] Next week’s podcast will discuss cinema, particularly a young Canadian director beginning to enjoy great success. Perhaps you already know who I mean. If not, join me next week to discover this very talented young director.

[00:31:37] Thank you for your attention, and see you soon!